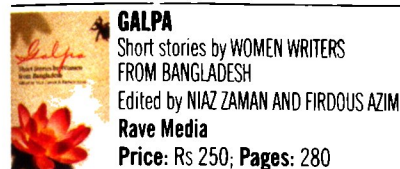


THE FEMININE CANVAS

The stories bear witness to overlaps of mood and experience of women's lives across the subcontinent



■ By Brinda Bose

There are dime a dozen anthologies of short stories by women. Are we supposed to receive them as feminist testaments? Sometimes, one is not quite sure what makes them feminist, except that they are all written by women, and we know just how unreliable such a categorisation is, given that it is the politics of gender, rather than its biological determinant, that makes feminism viable and vibrant. So sometimes, one cannot help but be impatient of yet another collection of women's stories—and three together that look and feel alike can nearly gag a reviewer's juices upon arrival.

Rave Media's reprinted bouquet of three anthologies from South Asia (originally published by Saqi Press, UK) may not quite grab you by the eyeballs, but looks are often deceptive. If you can get past the psychological barrier of singularly unremarkable yellow covers with meaningless red flowers or a predictable romantic riverscape painted on, you will discover treasures that will take your breath away. And even if you have read some—or many, or few—of these short stories by women of Bangladesh, India and Pakistan before, you will discover that there is yet reason enough to bring them together so, ascribed within geopolitical boundaries that simultaneously define and challenge their culture and their ethos.

For while it may be dangerous to homogenise the South Asian experience (and therefore wiser to keep sto-

ries of the three countries under separate covers, though united by the uninspired yellow-and-red look), the stories themselves bear witness to incredible overlaps of mood and experience of women's lives across the subcontinent, and in their telling prove the efficacy of a set that bears the echoing titles of *Galpa* (Bangladesh), *Katha* (India) and *Kahani* (Pakistan) and begs not to be separated in the buying and the reading, even if a total of nearly 60 stories are somewhat overwhelming

best-known writers of short fiction, ranging from the venerated, like Mahasweta Devi and Ambai, to the established, like Manjula Padmanabhan and Suniti Namjoshi, to the impressively young and restless, like Tishani Doshi and Aishwarya Subramanyam. The stories span half a century of Indian women's writing, and its range of experiential engagement and literary experimentation is printed proof of the unbelievable elasticity of its form and substance, coming in translation from a wide variety of Indian languages with equal ease and felicity.

Galpa, with 27 stories by women of Bangladesh is the most substantive of the volumes, despite being marked by its relative youthfulness, as an identity that was freshly registered only in 1971. Its editors Niaz Zaman and Firdous Azim remind us of this historical reality, even while anthologising writers both established and emerging.

for continuous ingestion.

The slimmest volume, *Kahani*, carries 13 stories by 11 Pakistani women edited by the London-based writer Aamer Hussein, and does not appear to seek to be representative of an immense range of Pakistani women's writing, though it spans almost an entire century of women's lives. Hussein's foreword, however, appears to yield centrestage to the flamboyantly self-styled Hijab Intiaz Ali who is allowed two stories in this volume along with Mumtaz Shirin.

Katha, edited by Urvashi Butalia, culls 16 stories from some of India's

Butalia leads the editors in articulating succinctly our initial vexed and vexing question about anthologies of women's writing: "Do women write their gender?", conceding that the issue has become increasingly clouded as the genre is no longer confined to traditional 'women's' subjects and subjectivities. She argues convincingly that such anthologies, however, contribute towards recording evolutions in women's writing from restricted to untrammelled, free-wheeling, and flamboyant. Now that, indeed, adds up to a literary as well as historical fea(s)t. ■



SAURABH SINGH